The Great Escape

When did bathrooms become so intentional? Mapping the shift from functional space to daily sanctuary

By **SOUVIK CHOWDHURY**

It begins with a subtle shift: a softening of the glow, a lingering steam, a fragrance that anchors the senses. What starts as a daily necessity quietly matures into a ritual—a private sanctuary carved from the chaos of the modern world. This signals a significant shift in the realignment of domestic spaces toward how intuitively spaces respond to the body and mind instead of being defined by spectacle.

Rather than recreating the overt language of luxury spas, bathrooms are now designed to respond to the lived experience that feels personal, sensory, and instinctively calming. As Pooja Bihani, principal architect at Spaces & Design, observes, the emphasis today lies in calibrated sensory moments. "How light shifts through the day, how materials feel underfoot, and how the space encourages pause," she says. This nuanced approach moves away from predictable spa clichés, instead allowing bathrooms to emerge as deeply individual retreats shaped by what Bihani calls "expressive surfaces or quieter, craft-led detailing in stone and wood."

This sensorial continuity extends into spatial planning as well. Layouts are increasingly designed to encourage slower, more immersive moments of unwinding. Freestanding tubs are positioned to engage with natural light, sculptural fixtures introduce a visual rhythm, while framed views become immersive moments of unwinding. "The bathroom is not a functional afterthought but an extension of the home's larger narrative. It is conceived as a private realm of retreat, where materiality, light and proportion are carefully orchestrated," says Sachin

Photograph by HARSHAN THOMSON



Photograph by ISHITA SITWALA

